

Von der Leyen endorses European space deal that is under competition review

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By Francesca Micheletti · Sep 10, 2026, 3:05 PM · [View in your browser](#)

PARIS — European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen publicly endorsed a proposed space joint venture between Airbus, Leonardo and Thales in a speech in Paris on Thursday.

Von der Leyen's intervention comes as the three satellite makers are in talks with the Commission's competition directorate on the deal, which raises complex antitrust issues and could require divestments to win approval. They have yet to submit a formal notification for a merger review.

She is also a prime mover behind an overhaul of the EU's merger guidelines, which in addition to traditional competition concerns would allow greater latitude for mergers that create European "champions." The proposed space venture, called Bromo, seeks to challenge the Starlink satellite-internet service operated by Elon Musk's SpaceX, which recently went public in the U.S. and is valued at €2 trillion.

"We have proposed updated Merger Guidelines — so that they recognize that European companies need scale to invest and compete globally," von der Leyen told French President Emmanuel Macron's International Space Summit.

"This is precisely what Airbus, Thales, and Leonardo are trying to achieve with their proposed joint venture called Bromo," she added. "These are the types of industrial champions we need if Europe is to lead in the space economy of tomorrow."

EU officials generally refrain from commenting on open antitrust proceedings. The Commission received a rap on the knuckles from the European Ombudsman when former competition chief Joaquín Almunia made public comments on an ongoing investigation into a banking cartel.

In that instance the Ombudsman said that comments about an ongoing cartel investigation from the then-competition commissioner created a "public impression of bias," and criticized the Commission for "maladministration."

Von der Leyen's advocacy of European champions has put her at odds with Teresa Ribera, her deputy in charge of competition, who has repeatedly warned that the updated guidelines should not offer a blank check for corporations to merge at the expense of consumers.

Jacob Parry contributed reporting from Brussels. Giorgio Leali contributed from Paris.

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